

MODERNIST LITERATURE

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Syllabus - D - Detailed, ND - Not Detailed

Imp - lessons in red are studied in each unit.

Unit-I -

Gr. M. Hopkins - Pied Beauty, Felix Randal,
The Wind Moves, Gods Grandeur - All D

W. B. Yeats - The Second Coming, Sailing
to Byzantium, Easter, 1916 - All D
Byzantium

Unit-II -

T. S. Eliot - The Waste Land - D

W. H. Auden - The Shield of Achilles,
Sept 1, 1939, Spain - ND

Unit-III -

Samuel Beckett - Waiting for Godot - D

John Osborne - Look Back in Anger - ND

Harold Pinter - The Birthday Party - ND

Unit-IV -

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E. V. Lucas - The Town week, A Door plate
D

Robert Lynd - Why We Hate Insects, The
Pleasure of Ignorance - ND

Aldous Huxley - Tragedy and the whole
truth, Selected Snobberies - ND

Unit V -

Khushwant Singh - The Train to Pakistan -
ND

Hasper Lee - To Kill a Mocking Bird - ND

Khaled Hosseini - A Thousand Splendid
Suns - ND

Unit-1

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W. B. Yeats - The Second Coming, Sailing to Byzantium, Byzantium, Easter 1916 - W.D.

About the writer -

William Butler Yeats (1865-1939)

Era & age - Modern age, Modern period (1901-1945)

Titles - National poet of Ireland

Admissions - Modern poets, Irish literary scholars

Critics - Political and mystical complexities

Contribution -

- Combined mythology and nationalism.
- Revived Irish literary culture
- Nobel prize in literature 1923

1. The Second Coming -

Central Message - Chaos is a never ending cycle.

Poetic form - Blank verse

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Themes - Religion, Spirituality, War

Emotions - Anxiety, fear, hopelessness, Nervousness, panic, Stress, Terrors

Summary -

Haunting depiction of societal collapse and impending doom, capturing the unsettling transition between eras with apocalyptic imagery and profound symbolism.

Flying around and around in a widening spiral, a falcon can no longer hear the call of its owner. Things are breaking down, and their foundation is giving way.

Pure destruction and lawlessness have spread across the world, and so have a tidal wave darkened by blood. All the rituals of innocence have been swallowed by this tide. The best people aren't motivated to act, but the worst people are impassioned and eager.

Some kind of revelation has to happen soon, and the second coming itself must be close. Excitedly, the speaker exclaims: "The second coming!" But just as the speaker says this, a vision comes

to the speaker from the world's collective unconscious.

The speaker sees a barren desert land, where a creature with a man's head and a lion's body is coming to life. Its expression is, like the sun, empty and without pity. Its legs are moving slowly, and all around it fly the shadows of disturbed desert birds.

Everything becomes dark again, but the speaker knows something new: two thousand years of calm has been irreversibly disrupted by the shaking of a cradle. The speaker asks: what beast, whose time has finally come, is dragging itself towards Bethlehem, where it will be born.

Symbolism - The Falcon - Chaos and confusion, breakdown in communication

The Beast - Similar to sphinx or mantichore - predatory towards humans. Humankind even improving capacity for destruction.

Poetic and Stylistic Techniques -

Alliteration, Allusion, Onomatopoeia, Metaphor, Rhetorical Question

a. Sailing to Byzantium -

Central Message - True meaning comes from art beyond physical life.

Speaker - An aging thinker

Poetic form - Ottava Rima

Themes - Aging, immortality, journey, nature, spirituality

Emotions - Faith, Fear, frustration, hope, Sadness

Summary -

This poem presents an aging speaker who turns away from a world driven by youth and physical pleasure, choosing instead a life shaped by thought and art, where meaning comes from what the mind creates rather than what the body can still perform.

The speaker introduces readers to a world that has no room in it for the elderly. It's a world in which young lovers embrace under trees full of singing birds, the waters swarm with fish, and every living thing - whether human, fish or bird - is born and then dies.

An old man in this world is nothing but a skinny, grumpy old scarecrow, unless he can keep his soul alive, vital and singing with his failing, worn out body.

No one can teach the soul to do this. For this reason, the speaker has taken a voyage to the ancient holy city of Byzantium.

The speaker addresses Byzantium's long-dead wise men and saints, who are now caught up in the glorious light of God. He wants them to burn up his mortal fleshy heart, which is tethered to his failing body and can'tathom or accept his own mortality and to take him up into their everlasting world of art.

Symbolism - Gold - Spiritual treasure, Things of true worth, riches of the soul, transcendent, eternal art

Art - Music and song, eternity

Birds and birdsong - mortality and immortality

Byzantium - Spiritual immortality after death

Poetic and Stylistic techniques -

Alliteration, Paradox, irony, epigram, onomatopoeia, apostrophe, allusion

3. Byzantium -

'Byzantium' is a sequel written to the poem 'Sailing to Byzantium'. In 'Sailing' poet talks of the journey to Byzantium but in 'Byzantium' the poet talks of his experience at Byzantium.

These two poems are commonly addressed as 'Byzantium poems'.

Central Message - Art and Spirituality can transcend death and achieve immortality.

Speaker - Reflective poet imagining / observing the spiritual world of Byzantium

Poetic form - Octaves

Themes - Mortality, Immortality, art, spirituality, perfection.

Emotions - Wonder, longing, sadness, mystery, spiritual desire

Summary -

This poem deliberates what happens at night in the City of Byzantium, through the ghost person perspective. As the night emerges, the day's activities recede. The drunken soldiers of emperor are asleep, and the song of night-walkers too fades along with other night sounds, after the great Cathedral song.

At midnight, the images float through the flames at Emperor's pavement. The fire seems to be self-generated and self-ignited for it seems to be neither wood nor steel.

Even the storm has no effect on it. The Golden Smithies of the Emperor ensures the perfection of the end process, while the flames ensure the speckles cleansing of the spirits on land.

Symbolism - Golden Bird - Spiritual and artistic perfection

Byzantium - Ideal, spiritual world of art

The Shade - Artistic immortality

Poetic and Stylistic techniques -

Paradox, Repetition, juxtaposition, Allusion, Alliteration

4. Easter 1916 -

Central Message - Sacrifice can change how people are remembered.

Speaker - A thoughtful Irish observer

Poetic form - Free verse

Themes - Death, Dreams, Identity, New Life, War

Emotions - Confusion, Grief, Guilt, Honor, Regret

Summary -

Written shortly after the Easter Rising of 1916, this poem reflects his mixed feelings about the event and the people involved. It shifts from judgement to respect, showing how tragedy can change both public memory and personal understanding.

The poem opens with Yeats remembering the rebels as he passed them on the street. Before the rising, they were just ordinary people who worked in shops and offices.

When reflecting on the rebels' constancy of purpose, as if their hearts were "enchanted to a stone", the poet wonders whether the rebellion was worth it.

The poem ends on a note of ambivalence and futility, reflecting Yeats' own reluctance to engage in political debate. The poem is divided in four stanzas, symbolizing the month of

April, the fourth month. It is known for its famous refrain, "All changed, changed utterly: A terrible beauty is born."

Symbolism - Stone - Rebel heart devoted to a single cause

Sleeping Child - Rebels after they died.

Poetic and Stylistic techniques -

Rhetorical Question, Oxymoron, Refrain, Simile, Metaphor, Climax

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W. H. Auden - The Shield of Achilles,
Sept 1, 1939, Spain NO

About the writer -

Wystan Hugh Auden (1907-1973)

Age and Era - Modern Age, Modern
period (1901-1945)

Titles - Voice of the Twentieth Century

Admirees - Modern Poets, Literary
Critics

Critics - Political poems as controversial

Contribution -

- Combined politics and poetry.
- Addressed modern anxieties.
- Influenced contemporary poetry.

1. The Shield of Achilles -

Central Message - Real world is cruel,
violent, and without heroic
glory.

Poetic form - Narrative / Lyric poem

Themes - Modernity, Youthfuly, War, heroism,
death, destruction, Meaninglessness
of War

Emotions - Horror, Sadness, pity, Disappointment,
Fear, Anger, Despair

Summary -

The goddess Thetis watched as Hephaestus
made armor for her son, Achilles. Thetis
expected the armor's surface to feature
images of lush greenery, dignified
society and ships navigating free, wild
waters.

Instead, Hephaestus forged onto the shield
the image of a man-made wasteland
and a gray, heavy sky. It contained
images sufficiently reflecting the
youthfuly of war - hidden world. Thetis
saw that although Achilles was a
strong, hardened killer, he would soon
die.

Symbolism - The original shield - Honorable
attitude of War

Modern shield - Death and moral degeneration
of War

Poetic and Stylistic techniques -

Allusion, Assonance, Consonance,
End - Stopped line, Enjambment,
juxtaposition, Metaphor, Synecdoche,
Simile, Alliteration, Paradox

2. September 1, 1939 -

Central Message - The Causes of war,
especially fear, hatred,
political oppression, lies and human
Selfishness.

Poetic form - Reflective Lyric poem

Themes - War and violence, political
Oppression, State Authority vs
Individual Responsibility, Love,
Connection and justice

Emotions - Anxiety, Fear, Sadness,
Anger, Disillusionment,
Loneliness, Hope

Summary - September 1, 1939 is the day
Germany invaded Poland and
World War II began.

This poem written at dawn of world

War II, captures the anxiety and
disillusionment of a world on the
brink of catastrophe. Auden begins in
a New York bar, grappling with
fear and uncertainty as he reflects
the moral decay and political
failures that led to the war.

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He critiques the authoritarianism, economic
disparities, and cultural complacency that
allowed for such violence to flourish,
referencing historical figures like Thucydides
and pivotal moments like Hitler's rise.

Despite the grim tone, the poem emphasizes
human interconnectedness and the
potential for goodness. Auden calls for
personal and collective action, urging
readers to create "ironic points of light"
through acts of truth and kindness.

While profoundly skeptical about humanity
past choices, the poem holds a fragile
hope that individuals, through love and
moral courage, can resist despair and
contribute to healing a fractured world.

Symbolism - Sky-scrapers - Authority

Light - Hope, resistance and connection